

Creole Gumbo

PREP: 30 MINS | COOK: 2 HOURS | STYLE: NEW ORLEANS CLASSIC

"The crown jewel of Louisiana cuisine. A deeply complex, rich stew built on a dark mahogany roux, packed with the Holy Trinity, spicy Andouille sausage, tender chicken, and plump shrimp."

INGREDIENTS

THE ROUX BASE

- **½ cup** vegetable oil or lard
- **½ cup** all-purpose flour

THE PROTEINS

- **1 lb** Andouille sausage
(sliced into ¼-inch rounds)
- **1 lb** boneless chicken thighs
(cut into bite-sized pieces)
- **1 lb** medium shrimp
(peeled and deveined)

THE HOLY TRINITY & AROMATICS

- **1 large** yellow onion (diced)
- **1** green bell pepper (diced)
- **3 ribs** celery (diced)
- **4 cloves** garlic (minced)
- **2 cups** fresh okra (sliced rounds, or frozen)

THE SIMMER & SEASONINGS

- **6 cups** high-quality chicken or seafood stock
- **1 can (14 oz)** crushed tomatoes
(Classic Creole variation)
- **1 tbsp** Cajun/Creole seasoning
- **2** dried bay leaves
- **1 tsp** Worcestershire sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

STEP 1: SEAR THE MEATS

In a large, heavy Dutch oven over medium-high heat, add 1 tablespoon of oil. Brown the sliced Andouille sausage until crisp and rendered (5–7 minutes). Remove with a slotted spoon. Season the chicken pieces with a pinch of Creole seasoning, add them to the same pot, and sear until browned on all sides. Remove chicken and set aside with the sausage.

STEP 2: THE DARK ROUX

Reduce heat to medium-low. Add the remaining vegetable oil and all-purpose flour to the pot. Stir constantly and uninterrupted with a wooden spoon or whisk. Cook for 20–30 minutes until the roux transforms from a light paste into a deep, dark glossy mahogany color (resembling melted dark chocolate). Do not let it burn!

STEP 3: SOFTEN THE TRINITY

Immediately dump the diced onion, bell pepper, and celery directly into the hot roux. The temperature of the vegetables will stop the roux from cooking further. Stir well and cook for 5–7 minutes until the veggies soften. Add the minced garlic and sliced okra, stirring for 2 more minutes.

STEP 4: BUILD THE STEW

Slowly whisk in the chicken or seafood stock a little at a time to prevent clumping. Add the crushed tomatoes, Worcestershire sauce, bay leaves, and Creole seasoning. Return the browned sausage and chicken (along with any collected juices) back to the pot. Bring to a boil, then turn the heat down to low.

- Kosher salt and cayenne pepper (to taste)
- Filé powder (optional, for serving)

FOR SERVING

- Cooked long-grain white rice
- Fresh scallions (thinly sliced)

STEP 5: LOW AND SLOW SIMMER

Simmer the gumbo uncovered for 1 to 1½ hours, stirring occasionally. The okra and roux will naturally thicken the liquid into a rich, sleek body. Skim off any excess oil that floats to the surface. Taste and adjust salt and cayenne pepper as desired.

STEP 6: FINISH WITH SEAFOOD

Drop the peeled shrimp into the bubbling gumbo during the final 5 minutes of cooking. Simmer just until the shrimp turn pink and opaque. Turn off the heat and discard the bay leaves.

STEP 7: PLATE AND GARNISH

Spoon a generous mound of warm long-grain white rice into the center of a wide bowl. Ladle the rich gumbo heavily around the rice. Garnish with a handful of sliced scallions. If using filé powder, dust a pinch over the top right at the table.

THE SACRED ROUX RULE

Patience Wins: The secret to a phenomenal gumbo lies entirely in the depth of your roux. Keep your heat controlled and your spoon moving constantly. If you see black flecks or smell a sharp, burnt odor, your roux has scorched—discard it and start over, as a burnt roux will taint the entire pot.